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E2 Speaking & Listening – Exam Prep Lesson 12: Discussion skills – Lesson plan and answers

Learners finish able to give an opinion with a reason, agree and disagree politely, bring their partner into the conversation and check when they have not understood. This prepares the discussion that ends Task 4.

Materials: Handout E2-12A, one per learner. Statement cards from the handout cut up, one set per group of three. Three counters, coins or paper clips per learner.

Activity 1: Five jobs in a discussion (25 minutes, teacher-led)

1. Write a statement on the board: *London is a good place to live.* Ask two strong learners what they think. Let them talk for a minute while the class listens.
2. Ask the class what the two speakers did. Draw out five jobs and board them as headings: *give an opinion; agree; disagree; ask your partner; check you understand*.
3. Elicit or teach two or three phrases under each. Opinion: *I think, In my opinion*. Agree: *I agree, That's true*. Disagree: *I'm not sure about that, I see what you mean, but*. Ask: *What about you? Do you agree?* Check: *Sorry, can you say that again? Do you mean…?*
4. Drill each phrase with natural intonation. Spend longest on polite disagreement. *I see what you mean, but* sounds friendly; a flat *No* does not.
5. Learners sort the ten phrases in section A of the handout, then check in pairs.

Activity 2: Keep it going (20 minutes)

1. Demonstrate a dead conversation with a learner: you give an opinion and stop. Silence. Ask the class what was missing. Answer: a question to the partner.
2. Board the rule: *opinion* + *reason* + *question*. Model: "I think markets are better because the food is fresh. What do you think?"
3. Add small reactions that show listening: *Really? Me too. That's interesting.* Drill them.
4. Pairs get a topic from you every 90 seconds and must keep talking until you call the next one: *food, buses, weather, phones, weekends*. The rule is that nobody speaks twice in a row.
5. Ask which pairs never had a silence and what they did.

Activity 3: Sorry, what does that mean? (20 minutes, teacher-led then pairs)

1. Tell learners that asking for help in the exam is allowed and shows good communication.
2. Board three situations and a phrase for each: you did not hear (*Sorry, can you say that again, please?*); you heard but did not understand a word (*Sorry, what does … mean?*); you want to check (*Do you mean…?*).
3. Speak to individual learners deliberately too fast or with a hard word. They must respond with the right phrase. Then repeat slowly or explain.
4. Pairs do the same to each other with questions from section B: one reads the question too quietly or too fast, the other asks for help, then answers.

Activity 4: Three counters (30 minutes)

1. Groups of three with the statement cards face down and three counters each.
2. A learner turns over a statement and reads it. The group discusses it for three minutes.
3. Each time a learner gives an opinion with a reason, asks a partner a question, or agrees or disagrees with a phrase from the board, they put one counter in the middle. The aim is to use all three counters before time is up.
4. Call time, collect counters back, and move to the next card. Do four rounds.
5. Monitor and note good examples of polite disagreement to share.

Activity 5: Discussion with the assessor (25 minutes)

1. Explain the exam: the assessor asks a question to both learners. They should answer the assessor and also talk to each other.
2. Fishbowl. Two volunteers sit at the front with you as assessor. Ask two questions from section B. The class uses the tally in section C to count what each speaker does.
3. Feedback from the tallies: which of the five jobs did the speakers do most and least?
4. Groups of three repeat the task, taking turns as assessor.
5. Close: each learner tells a partner the phrase they will use to disagree politely.

Answer key, Lesson 12

- **Section A:** Opinion: I think, In my opinion. Agree: I agree, That's true. Disagree: I'm not sure about that, I see what you mean, but. Ask your partner: What about you? Do you agree? Check: Sorry, can you say that again? Do you mean?